neonfeedback — contents

Doubtbound

2026-03-01

I may have been cruel, O Holy Father.
I may have broken what none can restore.
I may have sinned and forgotten.
Unworthy of mercy, condemned.

Oh, god, of shame,
you grant no absolution,
but demand confession without end.
I name you not as god but as disease.

I no longer weep for imagined crimes.
I no longer scour for certainty.
I no longer bargain with ghosts.
I forsake the dance that grinds the soul.

I accept that I may be wretched.
I accept that grace may never come.
This confession is fractured, profane, and enough.
I choose to walk onward, unredeemed and unbound.

The reality stack

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A stack is layers where each one rests on the one below — like a tech stack in computing, rock strata in geology or floors in a building.

Why define a stack? The stack exists to turn "is this just the way things are?" into "which layer does this object sit at, and therefore how contingent, how mutable, and how accountable is it?"

Why a reality stack and not *the* reality stack? Because "the" would imply there is one correct way to slice reality, there isn't. This is just one lens.

A note on motivation. The framework is descriptive in form but normatively motivated: it exists to make a particular claim about inequality arguable. The reader should hold both hands visible.

This is not original metaphysics — it is a teaching device for readers who need the distinctions made explicit before the political argument lands.

Layers of reality

There are three layers and one cross-section.

The **physical layer** is invariant law. Gravity, thermodynamics, the speed of light. You cannot negotiate with it. It gives rise to everything above but does not determine it. Examples: gravity, the speed of light, the fact that water freezes at 0°C.

The **material layer** is the physical world in the mode of human encounter: bodies, biology, climate, geography, and the infrastructure we have built into it. It is not philosophical materialism (the doctrine that everything reduces to physics) — it is physics considered through the lens of what humans need, what they are stuck with, and what they have made. Examples: the calorie requirement of a human body, the climate where you were born, the fact that there is a river here and not there, the concrete your city is made of.

The **social layer** is the constructed layer — arrangements humans make collectively, constrained by the material but not determined by it. Two societies with identical material conditions can organise themselves in opposite ways, and historically have, sometimes apparently on purpose. It is where power, roles, norms, and institutions live — and it is the layer people tend to mistake for one of the layers below. Examples: which side of the road you drive on, marriage, queuing, money.

The **agent** is not a fourth layer. An agent is a cross-section — a single point where all three layers meet. An agent has a physical body, material needs, and a social layer carried inside as language, shame, politeness. What is purely agent? Very little — a flinch, a heartbeat, a refusal. And yet the cross-section is the only site from which any of it can be questioned. Agents, acting together, reshape the social layer, which reshapes the material, which reshapes what is possible.

Locating a thing in the stack

To test where a thing sits, ask: *if the other layers were varied independently, would this thing vary with them, or hold constant?* Gravity holds across all societies and all bodies — physical. The calorie requirement of a human body holds across all societies but varies across species — material. Which side of the road cars drive on varies across societies within identical material conditions — social.

The test is not a decision procedure. Many interesting cases — gender, race, disease, addiction — pass it ambiguously, and that is the point: the framework surfaces the dispute rather than resolves it. Where the layer-assignment is contested, the framework names the contest. That is less than a theory and more than a vibe.

Natural and real

We are suspicious of the word **natural** because it often does covert work — moving a social claim down to the physical layer, where it can no longer be argued with. “Hierarchy is natural” makes hierarchy a law of gravity. “It is human nature to be selfish” puts a collective behaviour on the physical layer despite massive anthropological evidence to the contrary. The word has legitimate uses — naturalistic ethics, virtue theory, evolutionary biology all use it without sleight of hand. The suspicion is of the rhetorical move, not the word.

We are careful with the word **real**. Everything in the stack is real in some sense, but not in the same sense. A desk is real in a way that does not depend on anyone believing in it. Money is real in a way that entirely depends on collective uptake — if everyone stopped treating the green paper as money overnight, it would stop being money. Call these *brute facts* and *institutional facts*. The distinction matters: institutional facts are real but ontologically dependent on continued collective practice. “Money is real” is true. “Money is real in the same way a desk is” is false. The question “is it real?” is rarely interesting. The question “on what does its reality depend?” almost always is.

Boundaries between layers

The boundaries are fuzzy, and the fuzziness is load-bearing. The framework cannot settle any dispute whose resolution turns on where a thing sits — it can only make the placement visible.

The **physical/material boundary** is where physics becomes relevant to human life. A hurricane is physical; it becomes material when it threatens a city’s food and water. The **material/social boundary** is where biology becomes arrangement. A river is material; whether it is a border or a highway is social. Upper body strength is material; the social role built on top of it is not. The **social/agent interface** is the subtlest. The social is constructed by agents and absorbed by agents. The interface is where human arrangements start to feel like nature, where they become part of who you are rather than something you do.

Three axes, not one

Three spectrums run through the stack. They are related but not interchangeable.

Contingency — whether something could have been otherwise. Rerun human history from similar starting conditions; what comes out the same is necessary, what comes out differently is contingent. The physical layer has zero contingency. The material has some. The social has a great deal.

Mutability — how readily something can be changed. You cannot change gravity. Material conditions take generations — clear a forest, build a dam, industrialise. Social arrangements can change in a lifetime. An agent’s position can change in a moment.

Accountability — who bears responsibility. This is the axis the other two do not straightforwardly produce. A thing can be contingent and mutable and yet have no locatable individual at fault. Historical slavery was contingent in principle and mutable in principle, but moral responsibility under ideology, under incomplete information, under collective-action constraints, is not captured by “someone chose this.” Responsibility can be collective and forward-looking even when no individual chose the outcome. The stack's third axis is not "who caused it" but "who, going forward, is situated to change it."

Contingency is the descriptive axis, mutability is the practical axis, accountability is the normative axis. They can come apart. A thing can be contingent but practically frozen — path-dependent lock-in. A thing can be mutable in principle but collectively unaccountable — no agent is situated to change it alone. The interesting political arguments are always about which axis a dispute is on.

How the layers interact

The layers do not sit passively on top of each other. The interesting stuff — most of politics, most of history — happens at the interfaces.

Upward constraints. The physical constrains the material — you cannot build a skyscraper in the middle of the ocean. The material constrains the social — you cannot have a farming society in a desert. The social constrains the agent — you are born with the capacity to learn any language on earth, but which one you actually speak is entirely social.

Downward causation. The upper layers reach down and reshape the lower ones. You plant a garden — agent reshapes material. A village decides to build a well — social reshapes material. A revolution overthrows a government — agents reshape the social. The stack is not one-directional. This is what makes it a stack and not just a hierarchy.

Downward causation is philosophically contested. If the physical is causally closed, non-physical causes either overdetermine outcomes or are epiphenomenal — they do no work that physics is not already doing. The stack assumes *non-reductive physicalism*: higher-level facts have causal purchase even though they supervene on physical ones. This is the working assumption of most social science. It is adopted here rather than defended. A reader who rejects it will find the rest of the apparatus unmotivated.

Naturalisation. Something from the social layer is smuggled down to the physical. "Boys will be boys" — social behaviour relocated to the physical in four words. "It's human nature to be selfish" — the most popular naturalisation of all, despite massive anthropological evidence against it. It is a move to escape accountability by crossing into a layer where accountability does not apply.

Material lock-in. The social builds material infrastructure that then constrains future social choices. Once you have built a car-dependent city, the material layer locks in a social arrangement. A railway gauge, once laid, forces everything that runs on the tracks to match. The social created it; the material now maintains it. This is why it is much easier to imagine a different society than to build one: the old one has been poured into concrete.

Internalisation. The social becomes the agent when a person absorbs a construction as part of who they are. You lower your voice in a library — nobody is enforcing it, but you would feel like a criminal if you didn't. You feel guilty on a day off — the boss is gone but the feeling stayed. Language may be the deepest case. You did not choose your first language. It arrived before you could consent to it, it structured how you think, and you cannot unlearn it. Entirely social, yet permanent. Internalisation is not total: a trans person who rejects the gender assigned to them is demonstrating that the cross-section is not a passive receiver.

Emergence. Agent-level actions produce patterns no agent intended. A path forms across a field. Billions of decisions to burn coal produce a warmer planet. Indoor plumbing starts as a luxury and becomes a need. The social layer emerges from agents but is not reducible to them — which is why individual goodwill is not enough to fix collective outcomes.

Inter-layer feedback. An material difference (upper body strength) becomes a social category (gender roles), which is internalised by agents (gender identity), who then perform it in ways that reinforce the social category, which gets mistaken for a physical fact. The signal bounces up and down the stack, amplifying at each pass. By the time it has made a few trips, nobody remembers that it started as a small material difference rather than an immutable law of nature.

A stress test: gender

The easy examples make the framework look cleaner than it is. Here is a hard case.

Is gender physical, material, or social? The honest answer is that the framework does not decide — it names where the disagreement is.

A **biological essentialist** places gender at the material layer: sexual dimorphism, hormonal differences, reproductive asymmetry. If gender is material, much of what follows — gendered division of labour, certain forms of hierarchy — is constrained rather than chosen.

A **strong social constructionist** places gender at the social layer: a system of roles, expectations, and performances with no uniform biological signature. If gender is social, everything built on it is open to contest.

A **feedback view** — which is what this essay leans toward — takes gender as starting at the material layer with a small, diffuse difference, and escalating through repeated passes between the material, social, and agent layers until the social category towers far above any material signal that could motivate it. On this view the earlier two positions are not so much wrong as incomplete: each names one layer of a structure whose whole behaviour only becomes visible in the loop.

The framework's value here is not that it adjudicates. It is that it forces the disputants to say which layer they are placing the thing at, and to defend that placement. That is more than most arguments about gender offer.

Two examples

Walking. *Physical*: bipedalism, gravity, friction. *Material*: terrain — mud, mountain, flat plain, river crossing. *Social*: sidewalks, which side of the pavement you walk on, where women can walk alone at night, borders, trespass law. *Agent*: where you choose to go, whether you jaywalk, whether you cross a border illegally. A border is invisible at the physical and material layers — the ground is the same on both sides — but at the social layer it is one of the most powerful structures on earth. People die crossing borders. The dirt does not know.

Oil. *Physical*: chemistry — heat and pressure convert buried organisms into hydrocarbons. *Material*: the oil sits in specific places — the Persian Gulf, the North Sea, West Texas — unevenly distributed by geological accident. *Social*: who owns it, who profits, the decision to build a civilisation around the internal combustion engine. The same barrel could power a public bus or a private jet — that is a social choice. *Agent*: you drive, fly, cycle. Here the layers fold: agent-level consumption, aggregated, reshapes the material — CO_2 accumulates, the climate warms — which constrains future social choices. The stack operating as a loop.

Objections

A framework this ambitious attracts specific objections. The serious ones:

The stack is a pedagogical metaphor, not structure. Reality is closer to a tangled hierarchy than to ordered dependence; every "downward causation" sentence already admits this. The defence is modest: the stack is a simplification that keeps the explanation tractable. A reader who wants the full graph is right to want it; this essay is not providing it.

Layer assignment does the argumentative work, and is not independently defended. Charges of naturalisation presuppose the thing is social. This is fair. The response is the layer-membership test and the stress test on gender: the framework diagnoses rather than decides. Where the diagnosis and the defence of placement both fail, the framework has nothing to say.

Downward causation is assumed, not earned. Acknowledged. The exclusion problem — that if physics is causally closed, higher-level causes do no independent work — is named, not engaged. A full defence of non-reductive physicalism is out of scope.

The earlier treatment of "real" was too fast. The brute/institutional distinction above replaces it. Institutional facts are real but ontologically dependent; that is the substantive claim "everything is real" was hiding.

Accountability was being smuggled in. The move is no longer "contingent, therefore accountable." It is "contingent, therefore open to forward-looking collective responsibility." Weaker, and more defensible.

Normativity masqueraded as description. The framework is descriptive in form and normatively motivated. This is now stated up front. A reader who rejects the motivation can reject the framework on that basis.

Science thins as you move up

Science's power decreases as you move up the stack — each layer adds contingency, and science is best at the necessary. The physical layer is the most understood and still deeply incomplete. The material layer is well-covered by biology and earth science but cannot predict tipping points. The social layer is where science thins dramatically — economics claims to be a science but its predictions are poor, sociology is descriptive more than predictive, and there is no reliable theory of why some societies become egalitarian and others hierarchical. At the social and agent levels, where this argument lives, science offers tools but not answers. The rest has to come from somewhere else.

So when you catch yourself asking "is this just the way things are?" — locate the thing in the stack. If it sits at the physical layer, accept it. If it sits anywhere above, the question has an answer: it is this way because of the layer it sits at, the path it took, and the feedback that locked it in. None of that is destiny. That is the whole point of naming the layers.

Definitions of power

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A working list of definitions.

Power

Power is the capacity to bring about outcomes — by acting directly, by shifting another agent's behaviour, by setting the conditions under which others act, or by producing agents and possibilities that didn't exist before. It comes in five overlapping forms: *power-to* (capacity to act at all), *agentic power* (one agent shifts another, against resistance), *structural power* (a system shifts behaviour with no one willing it), *constitutive power* (the power to set the structure others operate inside), and *generative power* (the power to produce new agents, capacities, desires, or possibilities). The English word "power" smears across all five; pulling them apart is most of the work.

Power-to

Power-to is the capacity to act — to do, to make, to bring something about — independent of any relation to another agent. A solo inventor who builds a working prototype has power-to without exercising power over anyone. Most everyday uses of the word "empowerment" mean power-to.

Unpacked:

- *No second agent required.* Power-to is one-place; the other three forms in this entry are at least two-place. A castaway alone on an island has power-to (light a fire, build a shelter) and nothing else.
- *Substrate of the other forms.* You can't shift B's behaviour, sustain a structure, or write the rules without first being able to act. Loss of power-to (illness, poverty, imprisonment) collapses your access to the other kinds.
- *Often the thing actually wanted.* When people demand "more power" in their own lives, they usually mean power-to, not power-over. The two get confused because in a zero-sum framing they look identical — but most of the time they aren't zero-sum, and conflating them turns growth into domination by default.
- *Distinct from rights.* A right is a social claim that others not interfere; power-to is the underlying capacity. A right to free speech without a platform, audience, or safety to speak is a thin kind of power-to.

Agentic power

Agentic power is the capacity of one agent (or coordinating collective) to shift another agent's behaviour toward outcomes the first prefers, against the second's resistance, across some domain.

A collective counts as an agent here only to the extent it has coherent preferences and can act on them — a union with a strike vote qualifies, a "demographic" does not. There is no general way to combine many individual preferences into a single group preference without losing something along the way, so "the group wants X" is usually a faction's preference standing in for the whole.

Unpacked:

- *Capacity, not exercise.* Power is a disposition — it exists whether or not it is used. An unfired gun is still a threat; an unspent fortune still constrains the people who might need it later.

- *Counterfactual.* A has power over B in domain D to the degree that B's behaviour in D tracks A's preferences more than it would in A's absence. No counterfactual gap, no power.
- *Against resistance.* Influence that operates only through B's existing wants (persuading B of something B already half-believed, or offering B something B already wanted at a fair price) is not yet power. Power shows up where preferences diverge.
- *Domain-relative.* Power is always over some set of choices. A landlord has power over where a tenant sleeps but not over what they read. Conflating domains ("the powerful" as a class) hides where the leverage actually sits.
- *Mechanism-agnostic.* The shift can be produced by force, by control of resources B needs, by control of information B uses, or by shaping the options B can even see. These are different *kinds* of power, not different things.
- *On measurement.* Power resists reduction to a single scalar, but not measurement as such. Within a fixed domain it is often quantifiable — how often a voter's bloc is decisive, how concentrated a market is among its top firms, what share of wealth sits with the top percentile, how often a subordinate complies when told. What can't be measured is the *general* quantity, and the reasons fall straight out of the definition above: power is counterfactual (you'd need the world without A), domain-relative (no single scalar covers every domain at once), and mostly latent (unexercised capacity leaves no trace in the data).

Structural power

Structural power is the capacity of a system — a market, a bureaucracy, a body of law, a norm, a piece of infrastructure — to shift agents' behaviour against their preferences, without any agent willing the shift.

The observable signature matches agentic power: B's behaviour in domain D diverges from what B would choose unconstrained. The difference is in the counterfactual. For agentic power, *removing A* restores B's freedom. For structural power, there is no A to remove; the constraint survives the departure of any individual participant. A worker taking a low wage is not coerced by their employer (who may be replaceable, sympathetic, even underpaid themselves) but by the labour market — a structure with no author.

Unpacked:

- *No first agent.* The defining feature. Structural power often originates in past agentic choices (a law was written, a city was zoned), but once embedded it operates independently of anyone's current will. The agent who could change it may no longer exist, or may face the same structure when they try.
- *Aggregative.* Structural power is usually the macro-shadow of many micro-decisions, none of which individually shifts B. Each landlord setting rent at market is acting reasonably; together they constitute a constraint no single one of them imposes.
- *Invisible by default.* Agentic power has an antagonist; structural power has only a situation. People living inside it tend to experience the constraint as a fact of the world rather than a thing being done to them. This is what makes it durable.
- *Substrates.* Markets (prices coordinate without a coordinator), bureaucracies (rules outlive rule-makers), norms (defaults shape behaviour before anyone deliberates), infrastructure (the built environment makes some actions easy and others impossible — a highway routed through a neighbourhood constrains everyone downstream of that decision long after the planner is gone), language and categories (what is sayable bounds what is thinkable), path dependence (early choices lock in late constraints).

- *Resistance is collective or it fails.* Because no single agent is the constraint, no single agent can be pushed back against. Changing structural power requires changing the structure — coordinating enough participants, rewriting the rules, building alternative infrastructure — which is hard for the same reason the structure is durable.
- *Convertible to agentic power.* Agents who understand a structure can position themselves inside it to extract agentic power from it (the landlord who buys when the zoning is about to change, the lobbyist who writes the rule, the platform that sets the defaults). Structural and agentic power are distinct concepts but in practice each feeds the other.

Constitutive power

Constitutive power is the capacity to set the structure that other agents then operate inside — to write the rules, pick the defaults, design the platform, draw the map. It is agentic in form (someone wills the structure into existence) but its effect runs through structural power (once embedded, the structure shifts behaviour without further input). It's the bridge between the two.

Examples: the legislator drafting a tax code, the founder choosing the opt-in versus opt-out default, the engineer designing a road network, the standards body picking a file format, the early user-norm that hardens into "the way things are done here."

Unpacked:

- *Highest leverage per unit effort.* Acting directly shifts one situation. Shifting an agent shifts one relationship. Setting a structure shifts every interaction the structure mediates, for as long as it lasts. One unit of constitutive power often buys years of downstream structural leverage.
- *Front-loaded and rarely revisited.* Structures get set once, under specific conditions, and then carry forward by inertia. The people present at the founding have a disproportionate say in what everyone after them has to work with. By the time the structure is visible enough to argue about, the moment to shape it is usually past.
- *Often invisible while being exercised.* Writing a default, drawing a boundary, or naming a category looks like description rather than decision. The constitutive move is easier to make when no one yet sees it as a move.
- *Distinct from agentic power within the structure.* A senator voting on a bill exercises agentic power. The lobbyist who wrote the bill's framing exercises constitutive power. They can be the same person at different moments, but they are different kinds of move and they reward different skills.
- *Decays into structural power.* Once the structure is embedded and the constitutive agent is gone, what remains is structural power with no author — which is why old constitutive choices are so hard to undo. Reversing them requires fresh constitutive power, which is itself rare.

Generative power

Generative power is the capacity to produce new agents, capacities, desires, identities, or possibilities — to bring into existence things that weren't there before, rather than to shift, constrain, or arrange what already is. The other four forms operate on a given set of agents and options; generative power changes that set.

Examples: an education that doesn't just transfer information but produces a different kind of person; marketing that creates a desire where none existed; a category like "teenager" or "consumer" that, once named, produces people who think of themselves that way; a scientific paradigm that produces what counts as a question worth asking; a platform that produces new kinds of work (the streamer, the creator, the gig driver) by making those roles possible.

Unpacked:

- *Productive, not restrictive.* The standard image of power is something stopping you from doing what you want. Generative power runs the other way: it gives you wants, capacities, and self-conceptions you wouldn't otherwise have had. It expands the world rather than constricting it — which is why it often doesn't register as power at all.
- *Operates on the agent, not on their choices.* Agentic power leaves B intact and shifts B's behaviour. Generative power changes who B is — what B wants, what B is capable of, what B even sees as an option. The same external behaviour can come from coercion (agentic) or from desire (generative); the difference is whether the desire was there before the power acted.
- *Hardest to resist.* By the time you can identify yourself as a subject of generative power, it has already made the "you" who would resist. There is no pre-shaped self standing outside the shaping to push back from. This is why generative power is the most durable of the five, and the most contested in critical theory.
- *Dual-edged.* Generative power produces both the literate citizen and the addicted consumer, both the scientist and the conspiracy theorist, both the empowered worker and the precarious one. The fact that something is generated rather than imposed doesn't tell you whether it expands or narrows the resulting person's power-to.
- *Overlaps with constitutive and structural, but distinct.* Constitutive power sets the rules existing agents operate inside; structural power is the rules running on their own. Generative power makes agents with new capacities and desires for those rules to operate on. A school's curriculum is constitutive; what the curriculum makes of the student is generative; the school system as a self-sustaining institution is structural.

Egalitarianism

An egalitarian society, in the language of power, is one that simultaneously raises the floor of power-to, caps concentrations of power-over, distributes constitutive power broadly, and biases structural power toward enabling rather than constraining. Four dials, not one — a society that wins on any single dial while losing on the others is not egalitarian.

The temptation is to compress this into a slogan ("maximize power-to, minimize power-over"). That misses three things: some power-over is generative (teaching, parenting, contract enforcement) and removing it collapses the activity rather than freeing anyone; power-to itself can be used to harm others' power-to, so "more" isn't the target — "more, distributed, non-subtractive" is; and a society that equalises power-to and suppresses power-over can still be unfree if a small group writes all the rules.

Unpacked:

- *Floor, not average.* Power-to should be evaluated at the bottom of the distribution, not at the mean. A society where average capacity rises while the worst-off lose ground is regressing on this dial even if the aggregate looks good. The relevant question is what the least-empowered person can do, not what the most-empowered person could.
- *Cap, not eliminate.* Power-over isn't binary-bad; it's concentrations that matter. An egalitarian society tolerates the surgeon, the referee, and the teacher exercising power-over within their domain, and refuses to let any one agent accumulate uncontested, durable power-over across many domains at once. The target is to prevent *domination*, not to abolish authority.

- *Distribute the rule-writing.* Constitutive power is the dial most often left out, and the one that quietly determines the others. A society where everyone has equal power-to within rules written by a few is only as egalitarian as those rules. Broad participation in setting defaults, drawing categories, and writing law is itself an egalitarian condition, not a separate political question.
- *Structure as ally or enemy.* Markets, infrastructure, and institutions can either raise the floor (roads, courts, public education, healthcare) or lower it (debt traps, exclusionary zoning, monopolised platforms). Same substrate, opposite sign. Egalitarianism here means actively shaping structures so that their default operation expands power-to for the many rather than concentrating it for the few.
- *The dials interact.* Raising the floor of power-to without capping power-over lets the well-resourced convert their gains into domination. Capping power-over without distributing constitutive power just freezes the current rule-set in place. Distributing constitutive power without aligning structural power leaves participants writing rules inside a system that overrides them. The dials have to move together or they undo each other.
- *Not the same as equality of outcomes.* This definition is about the distribution of *capacities and constraints*, not of consumption. Two egalitarian societies on this definition could differ widely in income or wealth; what they share is that no one is structurally prevented from acting, dominated by another, locked out of rule-making, or living inside a system actively narrowing their options.

Legitimacy

Legitimacy is the property that makes power voluntarily accepted by those subject to it. Legitimate power runs on compliance; illegitimate power runs on enforcement. It is a property power can have, not a sixth form of power — any of the kinds in the power entry can be legitimate, illegitimate, or contested.

Two senses of the word, which routinely get confused:

- *Descriptive legitimacy.* A's power is legitimate iff those subject to it actually accept it as rightful — they comply without needing to be coerced each time. This is a fact about beliefs and behaviour. It can be measured by what people do when no one is watching.
- *Normative legitimacy.* A's power is legitimate iff it meets some external standard — consent of the governed, procedural fairness, justice of outcomes, rightful authority. This is a claim about what power *ought* to be acceptable, independent of whether it actually is.

The two come apart in both directions: a regime can be widely accepted (descriptively legitimate) but unjust by any defensible standard (normatively illegitimate) — most stable tyrannies have this shape. A regime can also be normatively legitimate by some standard yet rejected on the ground — most failed reform projects have this shape. Most political argument is one side appealing to one sense while the other answers with the other.

Unpacked:

- *Legitimacy is a compliance discount.* Illegitimate power has to monitor, threaten, and punish; legitimate power doesn't. This is why regimes invest so heavily in producing legitimacy (ceremonies, narratives, education, elections) — it's vastly cheaper than producing enforcement at the same scale. A power that has to be enforced everywhere all the time has effectively run out.
- *Sources of descriptive legitimacy.* Consent (explicit or tacit), procedural fairness (the right process was followed), outcome quality (it produces good results, or at least not bad ones),

tradition (it has always been this way), charisma (this particular holder is special), and identity (it was decided by "us"). Real regimes mix several; pure types are rare.

- *Maps onto every form of power.* Agentic power is legitimate when B accepts A's right to shift their behaviour in domain D — a referee in a game, a doctor in a consultation. Structural power is legitimate when the constraint feels "natural" or "the way things are" rather than a thing being done to anyone. Constitutive power is legitimate when the rule-making process itself is accepted as rightful — who got to write the rules and by what authority. Generative power is the hardest case: legitimate roughly when the subjects produced by it endorse what they've been made into, but they can only judge from inside the shaping.
- *Contested, not binary.* Legitimacy comes in degrees and is unevenly distributed across a population. A government can be legitimate to one region and not another; a manager can be legitimate to half the team. The interesting question is rarely "is this legitimate?" but "to whom, on what grounds, and under what conditions does that withdraw?"
- *Withdrawable.* Descriptive legitimacy is not given once and kept; it is renewed continuously by ongoing compliance and revoked when compliance breaks down. The moment of revocation often looks sudden from outside (a regime that "seemed stable" collapses in weeks) but is usually the visible surface of a long, quiet erosion.
- *Not the same as legality.* A law passed by the correct procedure is legal; whether it is legitimate is a separate question, in either sense. Legal-but-illegitimate power (a procedurally valid but widely rejected ruling) is the engine of most reform movements; illegal-but-legitimate power (a strike, a sit-in, a coup welcomed in the streets) is the engine of most revolutions.

Two categories of inequality

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There are two kinds of inequality, and confusing them is how the comfortable stay comfortable.

The first is **emergent inequality**: unequal outcomes that arise from fair-looking rules, with nobody intending them. Write rules that look perfectly fair, start everyone equal, run the system long enough, and you still get an oligarchy. Nobody cheats; the maths just favours someone. A fair coin-flip game where each player wagers a fraction of the *poorer* one's wealth ends with one person owning everything. Compound interest turns any gap, however small, into an exponential one. A child who reads slightly better at five gets more books, more praise, and by ten is years ahead. Networks reward whoever arrived first — links, citations, followers, all power laws. Queues signal quality and lengthen themselves. The same recession that inconveniences an investor destroys a worker. None of it is designed; all of it compounds.

- **Yard-sale model** — fair coin-flip bets, but the poorer player always risks more in real terms, so one player ends up with everything.
- **Multiplicative growth** — a 50% loss then a 50% gain leaves you down, so the typical fortune drifts to zero even as the average rises.
- **Pólya urn** — whichever colour is drawn first gets reinforced, locking in an outcome decided by the first few draws.
- **Preferential attachment** — new links attach to whoever already has the most, producing a handful of giant hubs.
- **Compound interest** — any gap, however small, grows exponentially at a fixed rate.
- **Matthew effect** — the child who reads slightly better at five gets more books and praise, and is years ahead by ten.
- **Assortative mating** — people partner within already-filtered pools, combining two incomes, networks and inheritances and passing them on.
- **Care work** — whoever does the unpaid caring falls behind economically, and the gap compounds across a lifetime.
- **Algorithmic feedback** — recommenders amplify what people like you already clicked, narrowing everyone into bubbles.
- **Postcode and passport** — where your parents lived sets your school, peers, safety and air, none of it chosen.
- **Network hiring** — most jobs come through personal connections, and your network is inherited.
- **Queues and bank runs** — people copy what others do, and the copying makes the original signal come true.
- **Gentrification** — rents rise slowly, then cross a line past which the original residents simply can't stay.
- **Language death** — a tongue survives until child speakers fall below the point where kids stop learning it.
- **Ecological collapse** — a fishery sustains a town for centuries, then crashes in a decade.
- **Asymmetric shocks** — the same recession, pandemic or drought lands softly on the rich and ruinously on the poor.

The second is **adversarial inequality**: unequal outcomes that specific, identifiable people create and defend because they profit from them. Here there are names, budgets, and lawyers — people who benefit from the gap and work to widen it. Landlords and patent trolls extract value they didn't make. Industries capture the regulators meant to constrain them and end up writing the rules. Employers suppress wages with non-competes and union-busting. Commons get enclosed; public assets get privatised and rented back. Debt is structured so the borrower can't leave. Profit is kept and the harm exported — to poor neighbourhoods, to offshore factories, to the next generation. Over all of it sits narrative control: think tanks and owned media funded to insist the arrangement is natural, deserved, inevitable.

- **Rent-seeking** — collecting a cut without producing anything: landlords riding a neighbourhood's improvement, patent trolls, monopolists.
- **Land banking** — buying land and holding it empty while the community's work raises its value.
- **Academic publishing** — locking publicly funded research behind paywalls, paying neither the authors nor the reviewers.
- **Privatisation** — selling off assets built with public money, then charging rent to use them.
- **Regulatory capture** — the regulated industry quietly writing the rules meant to constrain it.
- **Lobbying asymmetry** — one side has paid professional advocates, the other has day jobs.
- **Gerrymandering** — drawing the boundaries so the result is fixed before anyone votes.
- **Tax avoidance** — the wealthy fund the lobbying that creates the loopholes only they can afford to use.
- **Shareholder primacy** — treating "maximise shareholder value" as a law of nature rather than a 1980s choice.
- **Wage and union suppression** — non-competes, union-busting and wage-fixing to keep pay down.
- **Criminalisation of poverty** — fining and jailing people for being poor rather than for any harm done.
- **NDA culture** — non-disclosure agreements used to bury harassment and unsafe conditions, not to protect secrets.
- **Enclosure of the commons** — privatising shared land, water, knowledge and seeds, then charging for access.
- **IP maximalism** — stretching copyright and patents long past the original innovation to keep the rents flowing.
- **Credential gatekeeping** — demanding degrees for jobs that don't need them, to filter by class.
- **Debt traps** — lending on terms designed to keep the borrower owing forever: payday loans, inescapable student debt.
- **Planned obsolescence** — building products to fail so the customer has to buy them again.
- **Algorithmic pricing** — charging each person the most their data suggests they'll pay.
- **Externalised harm** — keeping the profit and exporting the cost to poor areas, gig workers, or offshore.
- **Transfer pricing** — booking profits in tax havens where the company does no real business.
- **Austerity** — cutting public services to cover a deficit manufactured by tax cuts for the wealthy.
- **Manufactured consent** — funding the story that the arrangement is natural, deserved and inevitable.
- **Legacy engineering** — trust funds, legacy admissions and elite schooling to pass advantage down the generations.
- **Violence and threat** — force, when the subtler mechanisms aren't enough.

In the real world the two braid together. Emergent dynamics open the gap; whoever lands on top then spends the winnings keeping it open. The emergence may be blameless. The maintenance never is.

That distinction is the whole point, because it kills a particular excuse: *this is just what happens when free people get on with their lives, so nobody's to blame and there's not much to be done.* Half true, at best. Yes, much inequality arrives unintended — but a process can be innocent at the start and ugly at the end, and the sane response is to change the process, not to admire how cleverly it works. The other half is plainer once you're looking: rent-seekers, captured regulators, paid-for stories. They aren't accidents. They're load-bearing. They're how the structure stays upright.

The fix has one shape in both halves, even where the targets differ. Where the dynamics push the wrong way, build rules that push back. Where people have built machinery to stop you, confront and dismantle it. Neither is easy; neither is mysterious.

Inequality is a choice. It can be unchosen. The main thing keeping it in place is the belief that it can't be.

What is matter?

2026-07-04

A summary of Noam Chomsky's **Language and Nature** (*Mind*, Vol. 104, Oxford University Press, 1995; PDF), archived by the Radical Anthropology Group as class text 095. The title is mine; the argument is his, and it is stranger than it looks.

The mind-body problem, in brief. We seem to be two things at once: a body — brain, neurons, matter under physical law — and a mind — thought, sensation, the felt redness of red. How can meat produce an inner life, and how can a weightless decision lift an arm? Fitting consciousness into a physical world with no evident room for it is the problem, and for three centuries it has been filed under *insoluble*.

Gilbert Ryle ridiculed Descartes's dualism as **the ghost in the machine**. The joke presumes we still know what the machine is. Chomsky's reply is that we lost it long ago — and that the ghost was never the difficulty.

1. **Matter, defined then destroyed.** The seventeenth-century *mechanical philosophy* held the world to be a machine: bodies act only by direct contact, and that contact was what "matter" *meant*. Descartes, unable to reduce the ordinary creative use of language to any such mechanism, posited a second substance, thought — and with it a real scientific question: how do the two touch?
2. **Newton dissolved the body, not the mind.** Gravity acts at a distance, through no contact at all — an "immaterial" force Newton himself judged an "absurdity" and never accepted ("I frame no hypotheses"). Leibniz and Huygens denounced it as a lapse into the occult. It was correct. What science expelled was therefore the machine, not the ghost; *body* is what vanished from the picture of the world.
3. **Materialism is therefore empty.** To say the mental "reduces to the physical" you need a prior notion of the physical — and since Newton there is none. "Matter" now means whatever the reigning theory invokes: fields, curved space, ten-dimensional strings, whatever is concocted next. Priestley drew the honest conclusion — not that all is matter, but that "the kind of matter on which the two-substance view is based does not exist." Thought is simply what a certain organised system, the brain, does.
4. **So study mind as nature.** Treat language and mind by ordinary empirical inquiry, with no metaphysical wall between the "mental" and the "chemical." Seek *unification, not reduction*: chemistry joined physics only after physics was overturned to receive it. Expect to leave common sense behind, exactly as physics left common-sense body behind.
5. **And keep the genuine mystery.** The *creative aspect* of language — speech endlessly novel, apt to the moment yet uncaused by it — was for the Cartesians the best proof of other minds. Of it, and of consciousness, we still have "only description and illustration," no theory. Not the routine irreducibility science keeps absorbing, but perhaps a permanent bound on a biological creature's reach.

The message is at once deflationary and immense. The mind-body problem was never solved; it was dissolved, the moment the body dissolved. We are not ghosts trapped in machines — there are no machines, only a nature far stranger than common sense allows, of which thought is one more unexplained part. The confident materialism of our age mistakes its own vocabulary for the structure of the world; the hard-headed naturalist who swaps the old God for natural selection and pronounces nature transparent has merely inherited a faith on worse credentials.

Newton's lesson, still unlearned three centuries on: it is not mind that defies physics, but our idea of what physics is.

How does anarchism typically die

2026-06-21

Anarchism is often dismissed as never having been tried. It has — repeatedly, at real scale, governing millions of people. The pattern worth noticing is not that it never works, but *how* it ends.

The 23 cases in the appendix below are too few for statistics, but enough for a shape. Sort them by cause of death and one bar dwarfs the rest.

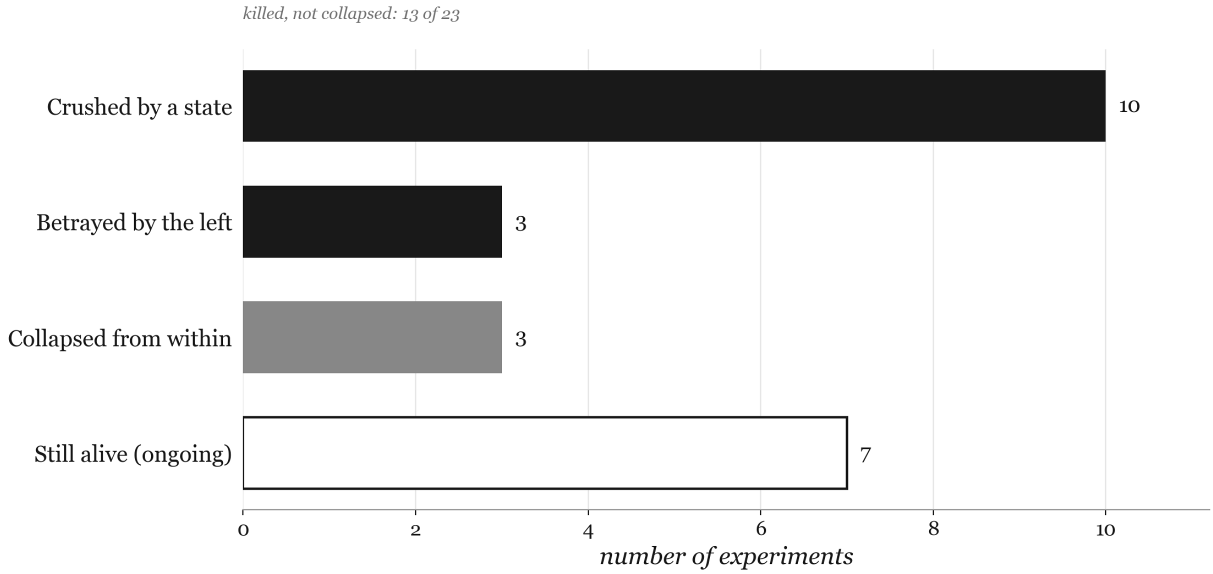

Figure 3: How the 23 anarchist experiments ended, tallied by cause: crushed by a state dwarfs the rest, while collapse-from-within is rare.

Of the 16 experiments that ended, only 3 actually *collapsed* from within. The other 13 were killed — 10 crushed by an enemy state, 3 betrayed by the authoritarian left they had fought alongside. The remaining 7 are still alive, and nearly all of them are small.

That inverts the usual obituary. Anarchism is supposed to fail because it cannot scale — because without a state it dissolves into chaos. But collapse-from-within is the rarest ending on the chart. Anarchism rarely dies of its own contradictions; it gets murdered, usually by a state, and at its largest by the left. The betrayals are few, but they land on the giants: the two largest experiments ever recorded, Makhno's Free Territory and revolutionary Catalonia, were destroyed not by their declared enemies but by the Bolsheviks and Stalinists nominally on their side.

There is a sharper catch. The big modern cases anarchists point to — Rojava, Oaxaca, Cherán — are mostly broad popular fronts or indigenous autonomies that anarchists *joined* rather than authored. Strip those out and unmistakably anarchist self-government at scale almost vanishes from the record. The most unforgiving reading: large anarchism does not merely die young — it is rarely permitted to exist at all. Whether the small survivors represent endurance or surrender is the open question.

Appendix

The full record behind the chart, sorted by peak scale.

The **bold** phrase in *How it ended* is the load-bearing claim each source is cited for — the manner of death (or survival) that the chart and the central argument rest on. Start there when checking a reference.

*† Anarchist-**influenced** rather than anarchist-led — a popular front, indigenous communalism, or worker-cooperative movement that anarchists took part in or claim, rather than a card-carrying anarchist polity. Iceland is older and shakier still: it is cited mostly by anarcho-capitalists and is here only as the one pre-modern outlier.*

Experiment	Where / when	Scale	Death	How it ended	Source
Revolutionary Catalonia & Aragon	Spain, 1936–1939	≈5–8 million in collectives	Betrayed	**Undermined by Stalinist allies**, then defeated by Franco	Julián Casanova, "Anarchism and Revolution in the Spanish Civil War: The Case of Aragon," *European History Quarterly* (1987)
Free Territory (Makhnovshchina)	Ukraine, 1918–1921	Up to ≈7 million	Betrayed	Used then **liquidated by the Bolsheviks** once the Whites were beaten	Altınörs, "The Makhno Movement and Bolshevism," *Capitalism Nature Socialism* 34(1) (2023)
Rojava (AANES)	North-east Syria, 2012–present	≈2–4 million	Alive	**Survives** under constant military threat from Turkey and others	Haval Ahmad, Emma MacTavish & Kenneth Christie, "The de facto Autonomous Governance and Stability in the Middle East: The Case of Kurds in Rojava," *The Journal of the Middle East and Africa* 15, no. 1 (2024): 91–110
Hungarian workers' councils	Hungary, 1956	Millions, briefly	Crushed	**Crushed by Soviet tanks** within weeks	Johanna Granville, "From the Archives of Warsaw and Budapest: A Comparison of the Events of 1956," *East European Politics and Societies* 16(2) (2002): 521–563
Paris Commune	Paris, 1871	≈2 million	Crushed	**Crushed by the French Army**; ≈20,000 killed in the *semaine sanglante*	Tombs, *The Paris Commune 1871* (1999)
Korean People's Association	Manchuria, 1929–1931	≈2 million	Crushed	**Caught between Japanese imperial forces and Stalinists**	Hwang, *Anarchism in Korea* (2016)
Biennio Rosso	Italy, 1919–1920	≈600,000 workers	Collapsed	**Collapsed**; cleared the path for Fascist reaction	Pietro Di Paola, "Biennio Rosso (1919–1920)," *The International Encyclopedia of Revolution and Protest*, ed. Immanuel Ness (2009)
Bavarian Council Republic †	Munich, 1919	≈600,000	Crushed	**Stormed by the Freikorps**; Landauer murdered	Cedric Cohen-Skalli and Libera Pisano, "Farewell to Revolution! Gustav Landauer's Death and the Funerary Shaping of His Legacy," *The Journal of*

Experiment	Where / when	Scale	Death	How it ended	Source
					Jewish Thought and Philosophy 28, no. 2 (2020): 184–227
Bakur self-rule †	South-east Turkey, 2015–2016	≈400,000	Crushed	**Turkish army sieges**; districts levelled, trustees imposed	Reşat Bayer and Özge Kemahlıoğlu, "Democratic Backsliding, Conflict, and Partisan Mobilisation of Ethnic Groups: Local Government Control and Electoral Participation in Turkey," *South European Society and Politics* 28, no. 1 (2023): 19–46
Zapatistas (EZLN)	Chiapas, Mexico, 1994–present	≈300,000	Alive	**Survives**, encircled and pressured by the Mexican state	María de la Luz Inclán, "Repressive Threats, Procedural Concessions, and the Zapatista Cycle of Protests, 1994–2003," *Journal of Conflict Resolution* (2009)
Oaxaca Commune (APPO) †	Oaxaca, Mexico, 2006	≈200,000	Crushed	**Federal police retook the city centre**	Marco Estrada Saavedra, "The Popular Assembly of the Peoples of Oaxaca (APPO)," *Oxford Research Encyclopedia of Latin American History* (2020)
Icelandic Commonwealth	Iceland, 930–1262	≈50,000	Collapsed	**Collapsed into feuding chieftains**; absorbed by Norway	Jesse L. Byock, "Governmental Order in Early Medieval Iceland," *Viator* (1986)
Strandzha Commune	Ottoman Thrace, 1903	Tens of thousands	Crushed	**Crushed by the Ottoman army** after ≈20 days	Perry, *The Politics of Terror* (1988)
Kronstadt Soviet	Russia, 1921	≈18,000	Betrayed	**Stormed by the Red Army**; rebels executed or exiled	Daniels, "The Kronstadt Revolt of 1921: A Study in the Dynamics of Revolution," *American Slavic and East European Review* (1951)
Cherán †	Michoacán, Mexico, 2011–present	≈16,000	Alive	**Survives**, legally recognised indigenous autonomy	Gasparello, "Communal Responses ... in Cherán" (2021)
Recovered factories †	Argentina, 2001–present	≈16,000 workers	Alive	**Survives**, pressured under the Milei government	Gürler, "Winning the right to work through solidarity: The Argentine workers' self-management movement," *Economic and Industrial Democracy* (2026)
Alcoy insurrection	Alcoy, Spain, 1873	≈10,000	Crushed	**Retaken by the federal army** within days	Moisand, "« Cantonards » et « communeux ». La révolution cantonale espagnole dans l'ombre de la Commune

Experiment	Where / when	Scale	Death	How it ended	Source
					(1873)," *Revue d'histoire du XIXe siècle* (2021)
Exarcheia	Athens, 1970s–present	Thousands	Alive	**Survives**, under ongoing police eviction pressure	Apostolopoulou and Liodaki, "Austerity Infrastructure, Gentrification, and Spatial Violence: A Ceaseless Battle over Urban Space in Exarcheia Neighbourhood," *Antipode* 57(1) (2025): 5-30
Magonista Baja California	Mexico, 1911	Thousands	Crushed	**Defeated by federal troops**; the PLM suppressed	Lawrence D. Taylor, "The Magonista Revolt in Baja California: Capitalist Conspiracy or Rebelion de los Pobres?," *The Journal of San Diego History* (1999)
Alt Llobregat rising	Catalonia, Spain, 1932	≈3,000	Crushed	**Retaken by army and Civil Guard**; militants deported	Ángel Herrerín López, "El movimiento de enero de 1932: ¿insurrección cenetista o asalto anarquista al poder sindical?," *Les Cahiers de Framespa* 25 (2017)
CHAZ / CHOP	Seattle, USA, 2020	A few thousand	Collapsed	**Collapsed in ≈3 weeks**; cleared by police	Seattle Office of Inspector General, *Sentinel Event Review: CHOP* (2021)
Marinaleda	Spain, 1979–present	≈2,700	Alive	**Survives** as a functioning cooperative	Candón-Mena and Domínguez-Jaime, "La Autoconstrucción de Viviendas en Marinaleda desde la Perspectiva del Gobierno de los Bienes Comunes de Ostrom," *ACME: An International Journal for Critical Geographies* (2020)
Christiania Freetown	Copenhagen, 1971–present	≈1,000	Alive	**Survives**, semi-legalised, under constant property pressure	Coppola and Vanolo, "Normalising Autonomous Spaces: Ongoing Transformations in Christiania, Copenhagen," *Urban Studies* (2015)